

EUROPE

Europe is the world's second-smallest continent, yet it packs in 44 separate countries, including two—Turkey and the Russian Federation—that straddle the border with Asia. The continent is densely packed, with most people living in the crowded towns and cities. Its land is generally fertile, although broken up in places by imposing mountain ranges and great rivers.

Scandinavia

The cold, northern European countries of Norway, Denmark, and Sweden together form Scandinavia, although the term is usually used to include both Finland and Iceland, too. While both Sweden and Finland are low-lying with many lakes and forests, Norway is mountainous, Iceland volcanic, and Denmark flat and very fertile.

North Sea

Dividing Britain from mainland Europe, the North Sea was once a rich fishing ground and its basin a massive reservoir of oil and natural gas. Today, overfishing has significantly depleted its fish stocks, and easily accessible reserves of oil and gas are also running out.

Alps

The collision of the African and European continents that began 65 million years ago pushed up the Alps and other mountains of southern Europe. The Alps form a natural boundary between North and Mediterranean Europe, but are now traversed by many road and rail tunnels.

